Taste the Table

Coca-Cola India

The Forward Trap

Every festive corridor between October and late November, millions of Indian phones choke on generic WhatsApp forwards, glitter GIFs, and empty texts promising "post-Diwali pakka milte hain." While brand campaigns preach "Milke Hi Manegi Diwali", real gatherings collapse into phone scrolls, roadside cigarette companions (Reddit: u/Cool_View9433), and 2L PET bottles that turn "watery or flat" in refrigerators.

Meanwhile, market pressures mount. Campa Cola wages a ₹10 price war triggering planned price cuts, while bottling franchises restructure via ₹2,000 crore divestments ahead of an anticipated $1B IPO. With Thums Up dominating hyper-masculine bite, Pepsi claiming youth rebellion, and Lahori Zeera owning post-meal digestion, Coca-Cola cannot play discount utility or aggressive fizz. Its only defensible cultural ground is the communal dining table—the exact space consumers currently abandon for screens and passive forward spam.

The Reframe

Every festive season, carbonated beverage marketing broadcasts high-production emotional reunions on linear television, urging audiences to "meet, not just greet." Viewers nod, glance down at their glowing screens, and immediately forward another automated greeting GIF to twenty contacts they will never see.

From broadcasting passive sentiment ('Meet, don't greet') on television → To weaponizing the digital noise itself into an enforceable dining table rule that turns spam forwards into real, shared meals.

Instead of ignoring festive digital fatigue, we make the spam forward the literal ticket to a meal. We stop asking people to put away their phones through polite, tear-jerking storytelling. Instead, we turn festive digital clutter into a social penalty: if you send or receive a lazy forward, you owe your crew a physical seat at the dining table. The screen becomes the trigger, and the table becomes the only acceptable resolution.

The Unforwarded Feast

The Idea: The Unforwarded Feast.

The Device: Phone Ulta, Coke Thanda (Phones Face Down, Coke On Ice).

A social-first communal crusade transforming festive greeting spam into mandatory group dinners. Instead of reciprocating impersonal Diwali GIFs, recipients hit back by summoning senders to an Unforwarded Feast funded via on-pack Coke Food Loot Swiggy vouchers.

At the dining table, the physical rule is non-negotiable: all smartphones are placed face down in the center (Phone Ulta). An ice-cold Coca-Cola is poured only when every pair of eyes leaves the glass screen and locks onto the feast (Coke Thanda). The first person to touch their flipped device before the meal concludes settles the food bill. It converts communal dining from an abstract brand sentiment into an unyielding, high-stakes ritual that rescues festive gatherings from screen hypnosis.

The Spine

The campaign deploys across four phased strategic buckets from 11 October through 25 November 2026, intercepting Diwali, Bhai Dooj, and post-festive wedding reunions:

- **Bucket 1: The 'Forward Tax' Calling-Out** — Calling out the epidemic of automated WhatsApp greeting forwards and converting generic digital spam into public social currency.
- **Bucket 2: 'Phone Ulta' Dinner Rules** — Establishing the physical dining mechanic across living rooms and hostel messes through high-stakes social dining contracts.
- **Bucket 3: 'I Know A Place' Festive Editions** — Scaling Coca-Cola's regional meal territory by dragging groups out to iconic late-night spicy food hubs across six metros.
- **Bucket 4: The 750ml / Can Rescue** — Eradicating the half-drunk, flat 2L party bottle dilemma by establishing instant, high-fizz single and multi-serve quick-commerce restocks during festive card parties.

Content Formats

Each phase deploys repeatable, platform-native content formats engineered to drive participatory virality:

- **Forward-Tax Vox Pop (Bucket 1):** Street interviews challenging youth to name three senders of gold-glitter festive GIFs and confessing whether they spoke all year.
- **Greeting-vs-Reality Meme Carousel (Bucket 1):** Split-panel meme templates contrasting WhatsApp family group floral greetings with awkward real-life silence.
- **Screen-Flip Penalty Skits (Bucket 2):** Creator sketch series documenting chaotic friend groups enforcing bill-payment forfeits whenever a flipped screen lights up.
- **Festive Adda Binge-in-Bits (Bucket 3):** High-cadence food trail edits following creators to midnight street counters, pairing spicy feasts with ice-cold Coke.
- **Anti-Flat Tactical Hijack (Bucket 4):** Rapid-response skits highlighting the tragic demise of half-empty 2L bottles, driving chilled 750ml and can orders on quick-commerce.
- **Comment-Section Dining Summons (Bucket 2):** Interactive callouts tagging guilty forward-senders directly into Swiggy voucher meal challenges.

Distribution Architecture

Every bucket is wired directly into specialized handle networks to ensure relentless feed penetration without relying on organic brand handle momentum alone:

- **Bucket 1 (Forward Tax):** Seeded across mass regional meme collectives, topical satire accounts, and city culture handles in Delhi, Mumbai, and Bengaluru, driving vox pops and static formats.
- **Bucket 2 ('Phone Ulta' Skits):** Distributed through comedy creator pods, lifestyle storytellers, and campus creators sourced via the SOLO marketplace to normalize the dinner table rule.
- **Bucket 3 ('I Know A Place' Trails):** Anchored by tier-one food and travel creators, hyper-local culinary vloggers, and regional food bloggers driving authentic late-night dining discovery.
- **Bucket 4 (Anti-Flat Rescue):** Amplified through pop-culture meme pages, late-night youth lifestyle handles, and quick-commerce food influencers coordinating card-party snack deliveries.

Proof

WLDD's execution capabilities across communal food culture and beverage entertainment have repeatedly delivered measurable audience scale:

- **Coca-Cola:** Deployed Amplification, SOLO, Memed, and Influencer services to orchestrate shareable social commentary off trending internet culture and communal FIFA watch parties, turning passive screen viewing into active shared occasions.
- **Thums Up:** Executed the 'Toofani Biryani Hunt' social-first food pairing activation through Amplification services, driving high-velocity food-and-cola cultural pairing across Indian dining hubs.
- **Regional Food Integration:** Native integration expertise directly aligned with @cocacola_india's runaway franchise 'I Know A Place' produced alongside servd.india, scaling regional dining narratives where video content drives maximum engagement.

Commitment

With Coca-Cola serving over 500 drinks per second across 2.6 million outlets, moving communal dining into culture demands exact execution parameters:

- **366k Brand Followers Activated:** Shifting @cocacola_india's publishing frequency from 2.2 posts per week toward short-form video to leverage its proven 18x video outlier performance ratio.
- **14.8M Reach Food Benchmarks:** Replicating the breakout metrics achieved by 'I Know A Place' featuring Varun Sharma and Gaurav Kapoor across festive night trails.
- **100+ Creators Mobilized:** Deploying over 100 mid-tier college and food creators across 6 metros via the SOLO marketplace to document genuine 'Phone Ulta' table gatherings.
- **Full Service Integration:** Executing via Amplification, Memed, SOLO, and Influencers to convert digital forward exhaustion into physical meal consumption across the 11 October to 25 November corridor.